

the besieged troops, provided the attackers with access to the walls for artillery points, and formed a platform for a final assault.

More than the surviving remains of their forts, the finest testament to the Romans' skills in military engineering is arguably the vast network of roads – some 120,000km (75,000 miles) long – they built to consolidate their rule. The first was the Via Appia, begun in 331BCE, which initially ran from Rome to Capua. Main roads linked the towns, making it possible to move troops quickly and to operate an efficient postal network. Military roads ran behind important frontiers, as in Britain and Germany. Roman roads were normally straight, regardless of local topography, and were carried over rivers and marshes by bridges or viaducts. Their durability owed much to their excellent construction, which involved a foundation of coarse gravel laid beneath layers of finer gravel, with large blocks of basalt added on top to form the pavement.



◀ THE SIEGE OF MASADA

To take possession of the inaccessible mountain fort of Masada, the last stronghold of the Jewish Revolt, in 73CE, the Romans had to build a counter-wall with towers and a gigantic assault ramp on which to mount a battering ram. The ramp was 225m (738ft) long and up to 200m (656ft) wide.



◀ A DACIAN CONQUEST

Roman legionaries are depicted on Trajan's Column (in Rome, dated 113CE) leaving a fortress to cross the Danube on a bridge of boats at the start of Trajan's Dacian War, in 101–02CE.

KEY FIGURE

HADRIAN

76–138CE

The emperor Hadrian ordered a retreat from advanced Roman positions in Scotland and had a wall built to mark the Roman frontier in northern Britain. It was defended by a complex series of forts, milecastles, and turrets.



▲ Hadrian consolidated the Roman Empire rather than expanding it. He even withdrew from some territories.